EHOJ ELOCIN

John Ferguson
Queensland Conservatorium
Griffith University

Nicole Carroll
Queensland Conservatorium
Griffith University

ABSTRACT

Nhoj Elocin is a collaboration of John Ferguson and Nicole Carroll. This project explores improvisation with lively and semi-autonomous processes in surround-sound environments using custom software and self-made instruments. While tactile interfaces are considered vital, algorithmic complexity provides a catalyst. Performed and captured via four speakers arranged in quad, Nicole's diffusion system affords exact but idiosyncratic spatialisation of sound, and she take overall responsibility for the placement of both artist's sounds in space. The overall agenda is to traverse noise aesthetics, contemporary computer music, and the repetitive rhythms of groove-based pop forms.

John performs with Mobile Noise Rig (MNR), this is a handmade instrument built around a Teensy microcontroller and an iPad. MNR features arcade buttons for tactile responsiveness and visual feedback, as well as a bend-sensor equipped hole-punch that underlines the potential of everyday and often-overlooked mechanisms. Bespoke software combines granular sample-mangling with lively approaches to vernacular rhythm and groove. Pseudo-random and generative processes place notions of 'imagined-agency' at the foreground. All of the MNR software runs on an iPad via Mobile Music Platform

(MobMuPlat). John's pseudo-anthropomorphic practice raises issues of causality, agency and legibility. MNR foregrounds the question: are we performing the technology or is it performing us?

Nicole performs with the Byzantine controller, which utilizes capacitive touch sensors on a circular grid (modelled after a Byzantine chessboard) that visually mirrors a surround sound configuration. The goal in developing this controller is to help merge the performance aesthetics of acousmatic diffusion with that of hacked electronics. Audio from homemade analog circuits is sent to Max/MSP, where pitch and amplitude tracking in conjunction with chance procedures control processing parameters. Chance procedures are driven by tarot card relationships and numerology as the software "draws" cards during performance. Direct and ambient light actuates a master circuit, ensuring a degree of uncertainty. The agency of the system–the machines in combination with chance procedures–prompts a responsive approach from the performer.